

bring something to the market -and that something has to be ready for prime time in terms of hardware, software and ecosystem.

It's not just the Windows 8 software that has to be on point. Although Microsoft is building the operating system, it might be wise to be intimately involved in development of some hardware -to help ensure positive user experience.

On the tablet hardware side, Microsoft will need to meet or beat what's already on the market. To that end, the company has said that Windows 8 will support multiple display resolutions, possibly even beyond that of the Retina display. With iPad in its third iteration and Android-based tablets past their infancy, consumers have an expectation of a mature, seamless and reliable computing experience, not one that is glitch or experimental. Windows-based tablets will be compared to what's already on the market.

One potential advantage is that Windows 8 is nothing like Apple's iOS or Android 4.0, or Ice Cream Sandwich, the Metro-style updating tiles will be a fresh approach to mobile computing, if executed properly.

- **Populate it:** Now that much of the buying public is familiar with at least the concept of tablet computing, Microsoft will have to deliver more than just a tablet and a stellar OS. "Ecosystems are driving purchases these days," Gartenberg said.

In other words, it's all about the apps. Windows Phone, essentially a precursor to a possible upcoming Windows-based tablet, now has 70,000 apps, or less than 5% of the market. That compares with half a million each for iOS and Android.

Microsoft isn't ignoring app development; it just released the developer's kit for Windows Phone 7.1.1, which can also run on the Windows 8 Consumer Preview release. In addition, Microsoft and Nokia announced an investment of about \$12 million in AppCampus, a mobile app development program at Aalto University in Finland, to develop new apps for the Windows Phone platform.

- **Sell it:** Price is an area where Microsoft could have a check in the win column. In just the normal desktop world, Windows devices were always less expensive than Apple machines. If Apple is the ultimate hand-held machine of the computing market, Windows-based machines have been considered sturdy and affordable machines. Keep the price down and sales may take off. That said, the premium price of iPads hasn't really hurt Apple's sales any.